פרשת נח starts with a fundamental and fascinating question which continues up until our very day. The פרשה starts (6:9), אֵלֶּה תוֹלְדֹת נֹחַ נֹחַ אִישׁ צַדִּיק תָּמִים הָיָה בְּדֹרֹתָיו אֵת הָאֱלֹהִים הִתְהַלֶּךְ נֹחַ. Rashi says on these words תּוֹלְדוֹתֵיהֶם שֶׁל צַדִּיקִים מַעֲשִׂים טוֹבִים. What is Rashi intimating,and what is the חידוש in these apparently simple words? The following answer is brought down by the אלכסנדר רבי in his ספר בית יעקב in the name of the ייד הקדוש מפשיסחא quoted in מעינה של תורה, the wonderful set of seferim from ר׳ אלכסנדר זושא פרידמן.

When after 120 every person faces the בית דין של מעלה, he'll be asked, "How did you spend your life? What were you busy doing your whole life?" Everyone will answer "I put in all my efforts for my children. I wanted my children to grow up to be גוטע יידן and בני תורה." What happens when those children grow up? After *they* get to the בית דין של מעלה and are asked the same question, they'll give the same answer "I said I spent my whole life raising *my* children that *they* should be גוטע יידן and בני תורה." Nobody cares about themselves; they only care about their children, all of their עמל ויגיעה is for their children. So the ייד הקדוש from פשיסחא asks, where is the person himself? Where are you? Where is that בן תורה that all the generations are working so hard to produce? That's why the pasuk says, אֵלֶּה תוֹלְדֹת נֹחַ נֹחַ - toldos Noach was himself. He saw himself as that child, as that son, as the object of all this effort and יגיעה. He worked to improve himself. He did not exert himself and put all his efforts in only for his children. He was worthy to be called the son that we're working so hard to make into a עושה מצוות. He was working at everything that he could do to serve הקדוש ברוך הוא properly himself.

That is what Rashi is intimating. תּוֹלְדוֹתֵיהֶם שֶׁל צַדִּיקִים מַעֲשִׂים טוֹבִים - He was putting in efforts for מעשים טובים. He was doing the efforts to ensure that everything that he did would be לשם שמים and that *he* would be the result of his efforts. Not only his children - not a bad thing, only the children - but that would be the result of working primarily on himself while not forgetting the children.

The מעינה של תורה presents a fascinating vort immediately after the above from the Brisker Rav, R' Yoshe Ber, (I assume it is the בית הלוי). He says: All of my life, I constantly yearned that I should never come to the phrase ברא מזכה אבא, [which is a famous saying in the גמרא, which means that after 120 years, the children are a זכות to their parents because they can continue in their ways.] The Brisker Rav said, "I don't want that. I want to be מזכה myself. I want to be able to say when I come upstairs 'I did what I was sent to do', and that is my ultimate purpose and achievement."

https://youtu.be/0Ue59n2kxJk